

# RIBBON WORMS

Marine worms of the phylum Nemertea are voracious predators, seizing their prey with a proboscis and swallowing it whole or sucking its fluids.

Ribbon worms are soft slimy animals, cylindrical in shape or somewhat flattened. Many simply wriggle across the seabed, but some can also swim. One species, *Lineus*

*longissimus*, the bootlace worm, has been recorded growing to 30 m (100 ft) in length. Like others, it has a fragile body that is easily broken.

The proboscis of a ribbon worm is not part of its gut, but emerges from a sac on its head just above the mouth. In some species the proboscis has sharp spikes for gripping or piercing prey, and even venom for immobilizing it. These well-armed species prey on other invertebrates, such as crustaceans, polychaete worms, and molluscs. Other ribbon worms feed on dead material.

| PHYLUM   | NEMERTEA |
|----------|----------|
| CLASSES  | 4        |
| ORDERS   | 4        |
| FAMILIES | 48       |
| SPECIES  | 1,350    |



**PACIFIC STRIPED RIBBON WORM**  
*Baseodiscus hemprichii*  
F: Valenciniidae

This colourful ribbon worm lives on reefs of the Indo-Pacific. It hunts for invertebrate prey on the bottom of the sea.

25–30 cm  
10–12 in

**RED RIBBON WORM**  
*Nipponnemertes pulchra*  
F: Cratenemertidae

Found in cold, ocean waters around the world, this ribbon worm varies in colour from orange to pink or red.

8–10 cm  
3–4 in

head

**COMMON ATLANTIC RIBBON WORM**

*Tubulanus annulatus*  
F: Tubulanidae

A large ribbon worm, this species lives in muddy sediment in intertidal or offshore waters of the N.E. Atlantic and Mediterranean.

smooth  
slimy body

12–75 cm  
4¾–30 in



# BRYOZOANS

These minute animals form coral-like colonies, filter-feeding with microscopic tentacles and, in turn, providing food for grazing invertebrates.

Many bryozoans resemble coral, but they are more advanced animals than cnidarians. A colony – genetically a single individual – is made up of thousands of tiny bodies called zooids, each consisting of a retractable fan of tentacles surrounding the mouth. Microscopic, beating hairs on the tentacles waft particles of food down to the mouth, which leads into a U-shaped gut. Waste exits by the anus in the body wall. Although a hand lens is needed to see individual zooids, colonies assume a variety of forms, depending upon species. Some are encrustations on rock or seaweed, others grow into bristly thickets or fleshy lobes. Many are heavily calcified like stony corals; others are soft.

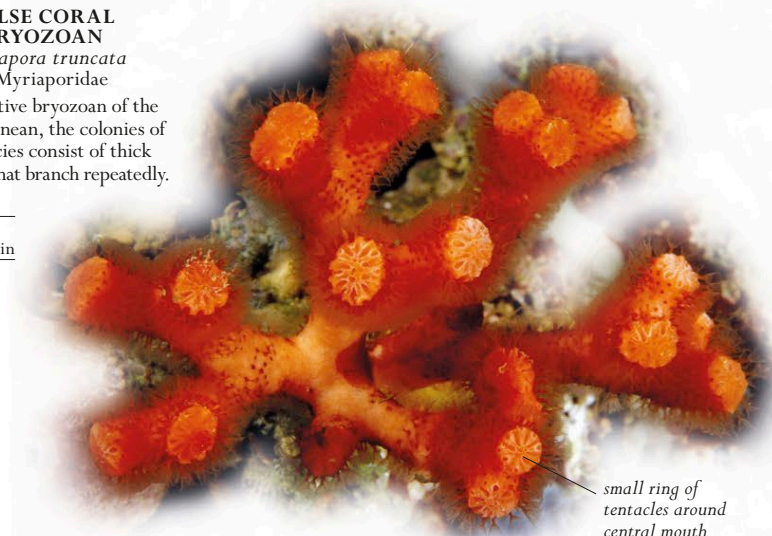
| PHYLUM   | BRYOZOA   |
|----------|-----------|
| CLASSES  | 3         |
| ORDERS   | 7         |
| FAMILIES | About 160 |
| SPECIES  | 6,409     |

**FALSE CORAL BRYOZOAN**

*Myriapora truncata*  
F: Myriaporidae

A distinctive bryozoan of the Mediterranean, the colonies of this species consist of thick cylinders that branch repeatedly.

3–4 cm  
1¼–1½ in



small ring of  
tentacles around  
central mouth

10–20 cm  
4–8 in

**HORNWRACK**

*Flustra foliacea*  
F: Flustridae

Typical of its family, this bryozoan forms erect leafy colonies. This stiff bushy offshore species is common on rocky N. European coasts.



5–20 cm  
2–8 in



15–20 cm  
6–8 in

**PINK LACE BRYOZOAN**

*Lodictyum phoeniceum*  
F: Phidoloporidae

Lace bryozoans – sometimes inaccurately called “lace corals” – form tall, rigid colonies. This colourful species lives on coastlines around S. and E. Australia.



**LACY CRUST BRYOZOAN**

*Membranipora membranacea*  
F: Membraniporidae

The bryozoans known as sea mats grow in encrusting lacy sheets. This species forms fast-growing colonies on kelp fronds of the N.E. Atlantic.